

## Overview

Observers play an assurance role within our regulatory system. They monitor, review and/or audit exporter arrangements on-board livestock export vessels.

Their focus is to verify and report on the:

- implementation of individual exporter arrangements. This includes its approved arrangement (AA) and approved export program.
- activities undertaken by the on-board accredited veterinarian (AAV) or accredited stockperson.
- exporters effectiveness at managing animal health and welfare. This includes meeting the Australian Standards for the Export of Livestock (ASEL).

Observers do not take an active role in animal management during the voyage.

Further information on the roles and responsibilities of exporters, AAVs, accredited stockpersons, master of the vessel and observer can be found on the [accredited veterinarians](#) page.

We deploy observers in accordance with the [independent observer deployment policy](#).

We publish [independent observer reports](#).

## Independent observer program objectives

In response to the Inspector-General of Animal Welfare and Live Animal Exports' review of the Independent Observer program, we have published the program objectives below:

- To provide the department with independent data collection and reporting relevant to the management of animal health and welfare during livestock export voyages to support effective regulation of the live animal export industry.
- To assess exporters' compliance with ASEL and relevant federal legislation, through verifying and reporting on the implementation and effectiveness of individual exporter systems, including their approved arrangements (AA), approved export programs (AEP) and management plans.
- To provide assurance and transparency to the government, department, industry and the broader community regarding the health and welfare of live animals on export vessels.
- To verify and report on the activities undertaken by the on-board AAV or accredited stockperson.
- To support exporters to take corrective action during and following a voyage, based on independent observer observations.

## Information for exporters

Deployments occur under 2 streams:

- routine annual deployment

- targeted deployment.

Learn more about observer deployment in this policy.

Download

- [Independent observer deployment policy \(PDF 338 KB\)](#)
- [Independent observer deployment policy \(Word 250 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing this file, [contact us](#) for help.

## **Destination restrictions**

We prioritise the safety of observers in decisions on whether to deploy an observer and may decide to not deploy on certain voyages where observer safety cannot be adequately ensured. Generally, we do not deploy observers to destinations with a Smartraveller advisory of level 3 (“reconsider your need to travel”) or higher.

Email [observers@aff.gov.au](mailto:observers@aff.gov.au) with queries related to observer deployment.

We arrange all observer travel and accommodation when not onboard the vessel. This includes domestic travel and accommodation until vessel boarding, and international accommodation and return flights to Australia.

To support observer deployment, exporters must:

- ensure suitable on board accommodation is available for the observer
- nominate a contact to support the observer at departure from Australia and on arrival overseas
- upload voyage instructions to TRACE at least 7 days prior to departure.

Where an observer accompanies a voyage, export and vessel operations continue as normal. AAVs and accredited stockpersons should perform their normal duties.

AAVs or accredited stockpersons submit daily reports under ASEL, including details of animal health and welfare during the voyage. Exporters must take timely and appropriate action in response to issues identified. The presence of an observer, and any observer reporting, does not change these responsibilities.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/live-animals/livestock/exporters/independent-observers>